

Applying for third-party funding

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Our questions for today

- How do I find an exciting idea?
- What funding schemas are there?
- Where do I find writing support?
- How does a successful application look like?

About me

- 2007 Diploma in English linguistics and literature, Perm State University, Russia
- 2011 M.Sc. in Cognitive Psychology, Rutgers University, USA
- 2014 Ph.D. in Cognitive Psychology, Rutgers University, USA
- 2015 - 2016 Lecturer in linguistics, University of Leipzig
- 2018 - 2023 Postdoc, Cognitive modeling
- 2023 - 2024 Substitute professor of Cognitive modeling (W2), University of Osnabrück
- 2024 - present Emmy Noether group leader, University of Tübingen



Do I really have to apply for grants?

I'm happy where I am, I don't need extra money

Position	German title	Number	Proportion
Professors	Professoren	51873	18.4 %
Lecturers (possibly with a second dissertation)	Dozenten & Asststenten	3638	1.3 %
Postdocs	Wissenschaftliche und künstlerische Mitarbeiter	214879	76.3 %
Lecturers	Lehrkräfte für besondere Aufgaben	11198	4.0 %

History of grant applications

- Emmy Noether junior research group (€1.3 mln) 
- PI in SFB “Common ground”, recommended for funding, decision pending 
- Marie Curie application 
- Athene-program at the University of Tübingen (€20.000) 

Where does it all start?

- Hey, I want to apply for a big grant!
- Great, so what's your idea?
- 🤔 😬 😬 😱



Where do you look for ideas?



Can you come up with an idea for a grant proposal in pragmatics.
The topic is "scalar implicature"

Absolutely! Scalar implicature is a rich area in pragmatics, and there are still plenty of open questions—especially about how it works across languages, contexts, and populations.

Here's an **innovative grant proposal idea** that's both grounded in current research and pushing into new territory:

Title:

"Contextual Calibration: Adaptive Scalar Implicature Processing Across Social and Cognitive Dimensions"

Core Idea:

This project explores how scalar implicatures (like 'some' implying 'not all') are modulated not just by linguistic context, but by *social cognition*, speaker reliability, and cognitive load.

Where to look for ideas

Group exercise 1: Discuss where you look for ideas and enter them on [menti.com](https://www.menti.com)

1943 6172

Where/how do you look for ideas?

60 responses





If I had three more years of funding I would do...

Group exercise 2: In a group of 3-4 people, present your ideas and say why you are excited about it (2 minutes per person)

Please treat this information confidentially

As a scientist, what do I want to explain?



As a scientist, I want to explain...

- What brought you to science?
- What do people whose work you admire do?
- What could you do with the unique set of skills that you have?





SPECIFIC



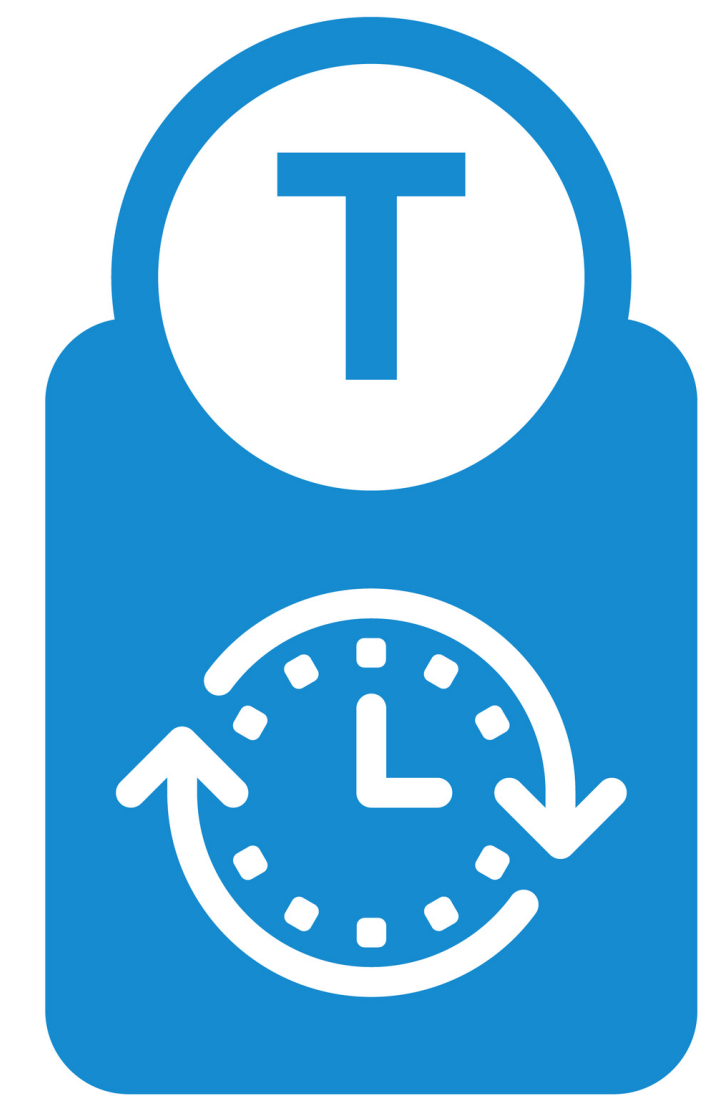
MEASURABLE



ACHIEVABLE



RELEVANT



TIME-BOUND

Doran, G. T. (1981). There's a S.M.A.R.T. way to write management's goals and objectives. Management Review, 70(11), 35–36.

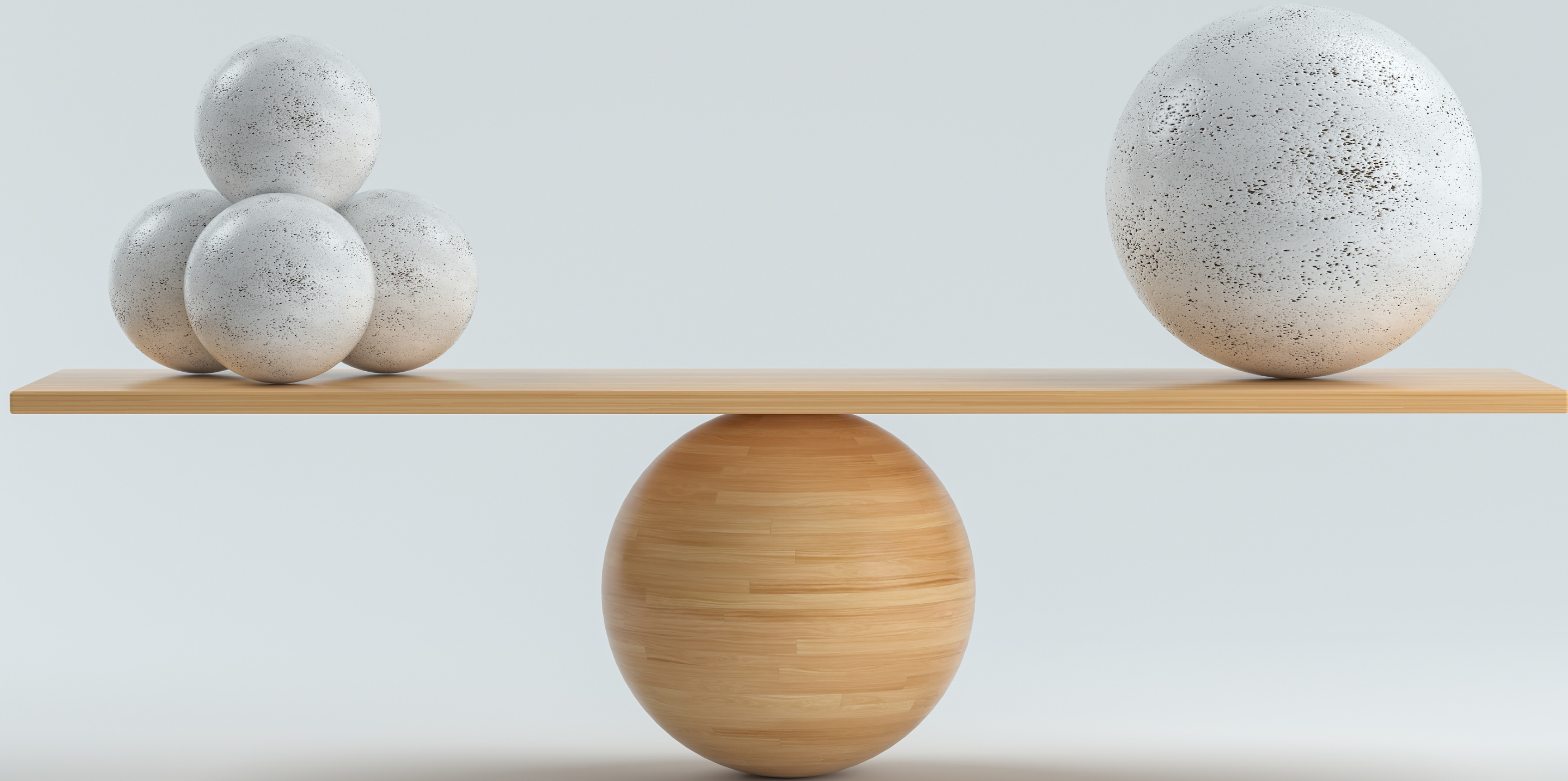
Questions to ask yourself

- Why this project?
- Why now?
- If all goes well, what will you achieve?
- How do you know that you have achieved your goals?
- Why you?

Unrealistically detailed

Previous work on the project

Novelty of the idea



It is never too early to start thinking about your next/first grant application



Give your idea time to grow

Give your idea time to grow

- Present it to your fellow Ph.D. students and postdocs
- Present it to people outside of your field
- Talk to a mentor who has experience with grant applications
- Start writing drafts early
- Revise, revise, revise
- If invited for an interview, practice with colleagues

Build your personal brand

- Academic website
- Google Scholar page
- Current CV
- Conferences presentations
- Asking questions
- Network
- International visibility



Funding opportunities

- Is there a deadline?
- How many years after PhD? Extension for children? For mothers? For fathers?
- What is the goal of the funding program? (write down the keywords)
- High risk?
- International experience?
- Restrictions on being in the country where you are applying?
- Funding for your own position?
- Is the use of generative AI allowed?
- Approval rate?

Funding programs

- Walter Benjamin program (DFG)
- Eigene Stelle (DFG)
- Emmy Noether (DFG)
- ERC Starting career grants
- Marie Curie (Horizon)
- Feodor Lynen Research Fellowship (Alexandr von Humboldt Foundation)
- Pioneering Research – Exploring the Unknown Unknown (Volkswagen Foundation)



Joan Miró "The Tilled Field" (*La terre labourée*)

<https://www.guggenheim.org/artwork/2934>

Group exercise 3: Miro boards Miro has free educational plans!

Resources

- University of Tübingen website

<https://uni-tuebingen.de/en/research/support/research-support/funding-for-postdocs/>

- Graduate academy courses
- Grant writing workshop from Graduate academy

05.05. + -06.05. + 12.05. + 13.05.2025, 09:00-12:30, online - Dr. Sabine Preusse (ERC experience)

https://lms-ubinfo.uni-tuebingen.de/ilias3/ilias.php?baseClass=ilrepositorygui&ref_id=36608

25.06.2025, 9:00-13:00 Uhr (online), **01.07.2025**, 9:00-16:00 Uhr (Face-to-face), **11.07.2025**, 9:00-13:00 Uhr (online); Venue for Face-to-face event: Wilhelmstraße 56 (Lothar-Meyer-Bau), Room 246 - Dr. Christine Schmidt

For current calls see [Research Funding News](#)

For information about special events and calls for Postdocs, please subscribe to our [Postdoc-Newsletter](#)

Information on specific calls: [Research Funding Snacks](#)

Expand all ▼

University Funding	+
DFG	+
EU-Programs	+
Foundations	+
Research Stays abroad	+
Funding for Female Researchers	+
Funding for Postdocs who want to come to Tübingen	+

Resources

- Max Planck info
- <https://www.mpipz.mpg.de/5266584/funding-opportunities>
- University of Münster
- [https://www.uni-muenster.de/imperia/md/content/CiM-IMPRS/postdoc fellowships and funding grants2.pdf](https://www.uni-muenster.de/imperia/md/content/CiM-IMPRS/postdoc_fellowships_and_funding_grants2.pdf)
- Uni Leipzig
- <https://www.uni-leipzig.de/en/research/academic-careers/postdocs/funding-a-postdoc>
- Uni Frankfurt
- <https://www.uni-frankfurt.de/111538424/funding-opportunities-for-postdocs.pdf>

Summary

- Check specific requirements for the grant you are applying for
- It may take a few years to build the necessary experience & publications
- User resources at your university
- Show drafts to your colleagues & mentors